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Library Column: Staying current in an ever-changing world

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George Williams Associated Press

Most of my job involves managing the circulation activities of all seven branches of the Latah County Library District, so I get to see the library world in Latah County from seven different perspectives. Another part of my job involves managing the day-to-day flow of library materials between our district and the rest of the 50 member VALNet library consortium, and I also act as the system administrator for VALNet's online catalog, so I get to see the library world from a regional perspective as well. And three or four times a year, I get to go to SPLAT meetings, so I also get to see the library world from a statewide perspective.

SPLAT is an acronym for Special Projects Library Action Team. SPLAT is sponsored by the Idaho Commission for Libraries and currently has 10 members representing every geographical region of Idaho. Several times a year SPLAT meets in person or online to talk about library trends, discuss the future of libraries and generate ideas for the SPLAT blog, and every summer, instead of meeting in Boise, we get together in a bunch of mini-vans and take SPLAT on the road.

About two weeks ago SPLAT members, working in three separate groups, visited libraries all over north-central Idaho. During our road trip, we spoke with library staff, trustees, friends and library users at about 20 libraries between as far south as Payette, as far north as St. Maries, as far east as Kooskia and as far west as Lewiston. Most of what we did was talk about library technology, but we also got to see how each library handles its summer reading programs, how they arrange their materials and how they deal with the day-to-day variations in library services in their local communities. One of the best things librarians can do to learn about the potential of libraries is to visit other libraries and talk with other librarians.

The thing I always take away from our SPLAT summer road trip is the scope of what small Idaho libraries are able to do with their limited resources. Although our library district serves 38,000 people in Latah County and we're considered a small- to medium-size library by national standards, in Idaho we're a rather large system. Compared to Tensed, Fernwood and Clarkia, the best words to describe Moscow Public Library would be "huge" and "enormous." But size and a limited budget don't seem to stop any of these libraries, or even our own smaller branches in Bovill, Deary, Genesee, Juliaetta, Potlatch and Troy, from doing

incredible things with the resources they have available.

All of my involvement in SPLAT and VALNet and our own district is important to me because it means that I'm not always focused on one library. Our district's membership in VALNet, the district's willingness to let me be involved in SPLAT and the district's encouragement of staff to be involved in the Idaho Library Association as well as other regional organizations helps us look at the big picture of the library world. Getting staff to look beyond one individual library helps Latah County Library District move forward in the ever-changing world of library service.

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